

Greek mythology features a number of characters that possess many of the traits of a robot. *Hephaestus*, the Greek God of craftsmen, made a three-legged table capable of moving around on its own, and a man made out of bronze called Talos. Back home, there are legends of King Ajatashatru of Magadha dynasty gathering Buddha's relics and hiding them somewhere underground protected by robots or '*bbuta vahana yantra*'.

The first documented account of a robot can be traced back to 4th Century BC Greece, where a mathematician called Archytas of Tarentum designed a mechanical bird called 'Pigeon', propelled by steam. Throughout history, there have been many similar designs and mentions of devices that look and work like a robot.

Industrial robots led to robots becoming more mainstream. Robots could not only increase the efficiency and accuracy, but also reduce the number of workers required. The first robot to be used on a production line was the Unimate Robot. It was first installed in the General Motors, Ternstedt plant in USA. The robot had a 4,000 pound heavy arm that was programmed to stack hot pieces of metals.

Within the next two decades, robots had started to gain a foothold in industry and there were more than 3,000 industrial robots in operation around the globe. Currently, there are more than 1.3 million robots being used in various industries and the number is going to keep on rising.

Types of robots and their uses

According to the International Federation of Robotics, robots today can be categorised into two categories – service robots and industrial robots. Industrial robots have revolutionised the production world, increasing the efficiency and reducing manual labour significantly. This \$9.5 billion dollar industry is only going to grow.



Hephaestus was the Greek God of craftsmanship credited with making the first robots.